

Getting Into... Bluegrass Mandolin

(Book and CD)

MB20099BCD

MEL BAY'S GETTING TO.....



BLUEGRASS MANDOLIN

by

DIX BRUCE



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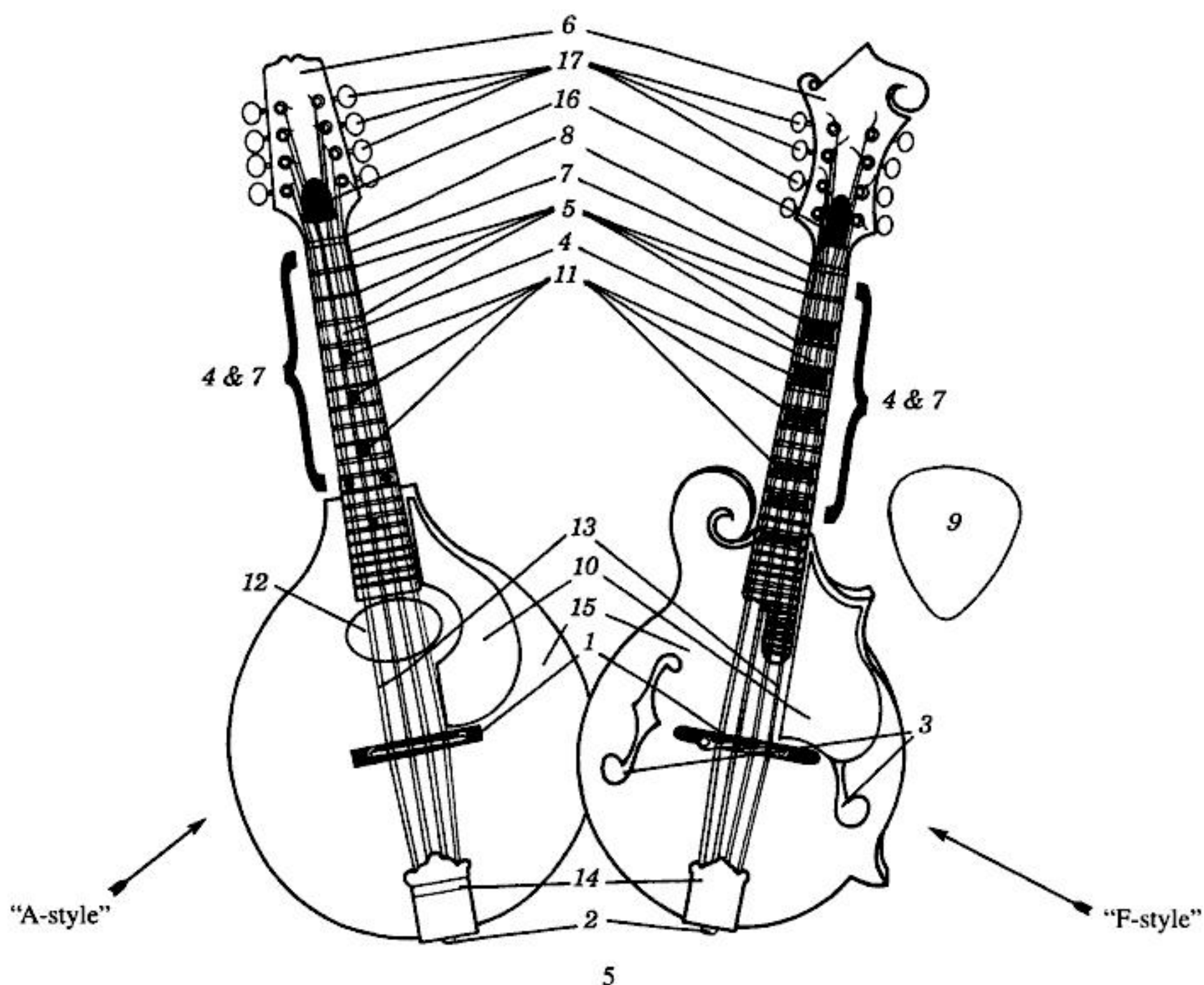
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The Mandolin and its Parts

Your mandolin is probably similar to one of two basic models: A-style or F-style. If you're playing a round-back or "taterbug," its face will be similar to the A-model. Take a look at the diagram below and familiarize yourself with the different parts of the mandolin. Read through the text and find out why these parts are important. You should know the difference between a headstock and an end pin. You can always refer back to this diagram as we explore the mandolin in more depth.

1. **Bridge.** Strings rest on the bridge, which conducts their vibration to the resonant top of the mandolin. Nearly all mandolin bridges "float," held onto the top only by the tension of the strings. As such, bridges move and may need to be corrected periodically to insure proper tuning and intonation. Some bridges are height adjustable by two small wheels imbedded in the bridge itself.
2. **End Pin.** The end pin holds one end of your strap. If you have an F-style mandolin, use a leather lace or strap and tie the other end of the strap around the curl. If your mandolin doesn't have a curl, tie the other end onto the headstock (6), under the strings near the nut (8).
3. **F-hole.** F-holes are sound holes shaped like a script letter "f" as on a violin. After the music goes round and round, it comes out here. Other mandolins, like the A-style, have oval-shaped sound holes (see #12 below).
4. **Fretboard or Fingerboard.** This is where your fingers press the strings to make different notes and chords. Always place your fretting finger in the space between the metal frets, not on the metal frets themselves.



Picks

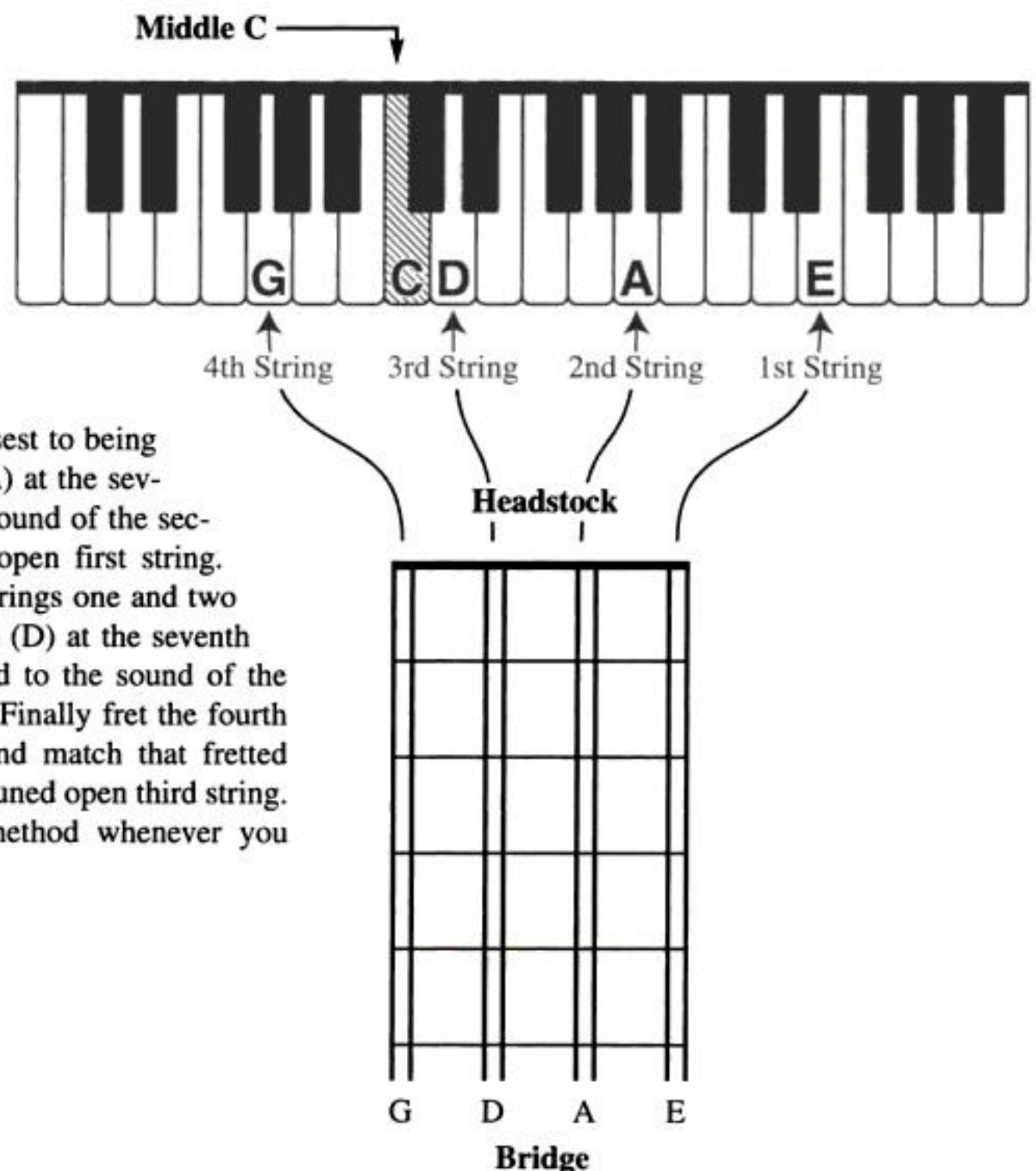
I suggest that you try picks in a variety of shapes and thicknesses. Most players I know settle on some type of heavy pick. I use a standard Fender heavy. I'm used to them, and they are widely available. Stay away from real tortoise shell picks. They're expensive, illegal, and they come from an endangered species. *Dawg Picks* are currently in vogue. They are super stiff and David Grisman designed them to simulate the sound and feel of tortoise shell. (For *Dawg Pick* info: www.musixnow.com).

Tuning the Mandolin

Mandolins are tuned like violins, except that violins have only one string for each pitch, and mandolins have two. Each string in the pair is tuned to one of the notes shown below. Tune to the tones at the beginning of the CD, use an electronic tuner, or tune to the piano. Tuning notes on the piano are shown below. Start with string #1, the E (thinnest string) and get one of the pair in tune to your source, then tune the other in the pair to it. Listen to the "How to Tune" on the CD.

Getting your mandolin in tune requires lots of practice and listening. Be sure to work on it every time you play your instrument. It will develop over time. If you can't hear what's in tune yet, don't worry about it, but have someone help you tune your mandolin from time to time. The most popular and probably the most effective tuner for an acoustic mandolin is the *Intellitouch*, which clips on the mandolin headstock and senses the vibrations of the strings.

If you don't have access to any reliable tuning tones, you can still get your mandolin in tune with itself. First you have to decide which of the strings is most in tune and tune the others to it. Let's assume that the first string E (far right as you look at the fingerboard and thinnest) is the closest to being correct. Fret the second string (A) at the seventh fret and match that fretted sound of the second string to the sound of the open first string. When these match you'll have strings one and two in tune. Now fret the third string (D) at the seventh fret and match that fretted sound to the sound of the newly tuned open second string. Finally fret the fourth string (G) at the seventh fret and match that fretted sound to the sound of the newly tuned open third string. Use this "fretted/open-string" method whenever you need to check your tuning.



tion. Standard notation doesn't usually come with tab. Most of the "serious" music world reads and writes standard notation. If you learn to read it, you can play with millions of musicians of all kinds all over the world, from classical to jazz. It takes just about as long to learn to read notes as it does to read tablature.

On the other hand, tab can be very useful to players who are just beginning on their instruments and don't want to take the time to learn to read music. While tab can be helpful in showing a player exactly where a note is located on a fretboard or getting a beginner started, it can ultimately be very limiting if a player doesn't eventually move beyond a dependence on tab.

I suggest that you use tab to get started but if you only learn one system, standard notation will be much more useful in the long run. My "You Can Teach Yourself Mandolin" as a good place to start for learning basic music reading. Below is a brief explanation of the style of tab I use.

Numbers, which correspond to the fret where the note is played, are arranged on a four line staff, each line representing one of the strings on the mandolin. The top line of the tablature staff represents the first or highest pitched string (E) of the mandolin, second from the top is the second string (A), third from the top is the third string (D), and the bottom line is the fourth string (G).

A zero on any of the lines means to play that string unfretted or open. If you see a numeral "1," put your fretting finger on the first fret of whatever string is designated and pick the note. The numbers in italics (1, 2, 3, 4)

directly above or below the tablature line tell you which fretting hand finger to use to fret a note. You'll see quite a few of these finger notations in the first few songs. After that, if a melody note repeats, we'll leave out the fretting finger designation for the sake of clarity in the music. Eventually we'll leave them out altogether, unless there's an unusual fingering I want to point out, and you'll be able to figure them out for yourself.



In the example below we see the melody and chords to "Camptown Races" shown in standard notation. Below the music staff you'll find the corresponding tablature staff. The first two G notes are played at the fifth fret of the third string. The next note, an E, is played at the second fret of the third string. This is followed by another G. In the next measure, the first note is an A, played on the open second string. Fretting finger numbers are shown in italics below the lyrics and above the tablature staff. We're suddenly swimming in numbers here so don't get confused. Remember that the tablature numbers are on the horizontal lines. Fretting finger numbers are above the lines and shown in italics.

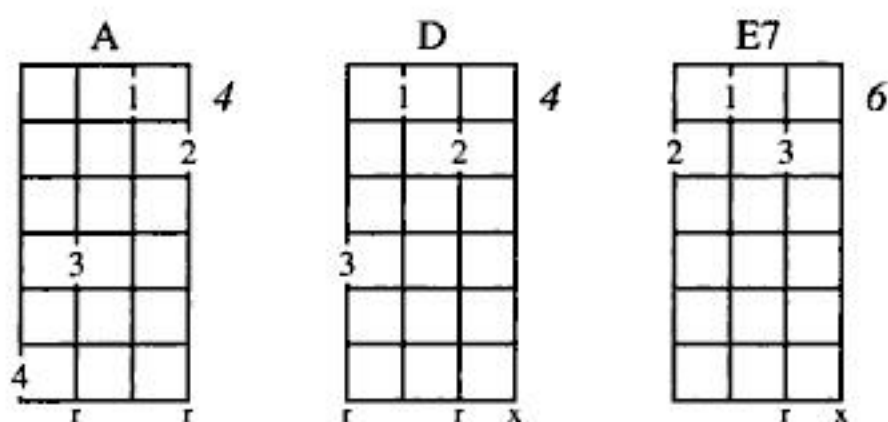
C				G7			
Camp - town la - dies sing this song, "Doo - dah, Doo - dah," <i>3 3 1 3 3 1 1 1</i>							
5 5 2 5 0 5 2 2 (2) (0) (0)							

Try "John Hardy," an old time bluegrass standard, in the key of C. For backup rhythm, you can use the chords shown above or look up their closed position counterparts in the Mandolin Chord Dictionary on page 88. Use the simple single down-stroke strum. Listen first and then play along with "John Hardy" on the CD.

In a bluegrass band, the mandolinist plays several roles:

- 1) lead soloist playing melodies,
- 2) accompanist playing chords,
- 3) “drummer” playing solid rhythmic backbeats;
- 4) accompanist playing tasteful background lines and fills behind the vocalist, and
- 5) babe or dude magnet, as the case may be.

In playing bluegrass rhythm, the mandolinist accomplishes #2 and #3 at the same time supplying accompaniment chords and backbeat rhythm. Before we go any further, listen to a demonstration of “Bluegrass Mandolin Rhythm” and “Bluegrass Chop” on the CD and look at the rhythm diagram below. These chord forms have no open-string notes. They can be moved to different positions up and down the neck to make different chords. The small number to the right of the chord grid tells at which fret number the form should be placed and acts as an anchor point for our fretting fingers. More on that in a minute. In the A and D below, the first finger of your fretting hand should be in fret number four. In the E7, the first finger of your fretting hand should be in fret number six. Try to play along with the CD and learn the new chords.



As you listen to the recorded examples and study the rhythm chart, notice that the mandolin doesn't strum on every beat. Each of the measures in this song has four beats: 1, 2, 3, and 4. The guitar plays bass notes on beats 1 and 3, known as the downbeats. Strums on beats 2 and 4, are known as the backbeats. The mandolin strums on beats 2 and 4, the backbeats, with the guitar strum, and does not play or “rests” on beats 1 and 3. If we had a string bass on the recording, the bass would play its notes on beats 1 and 3, the downbeats, with the guitar bass notes. See the rhythm diagram on page 18.

Altogether it's like a drummer's basic groove in a rock or country band. The drummer “kicks” the bass drum on the downbeats, beats 1 and 3, and plays the snare on the backbeats, 2 and 4. The role of the mandolin is like that of the snare drum and except for accents and special fills, the mandolin always plays on beats 2 and 4 and rests on beats 1 and 3. If you have trouble resting on beats 1 and 3 and fitting in the chops on 2 and 4, try playing a very light click on 1 and 3 just to keep your own rhythm together. You want it to be very light, virtually unheard by anyone else and eventually you'll want to stop playing it altogether. Listen to “More on Chop Chords” on the CD.

Once you can play a few chords and have begun your love affair with lead playing, you'll have a tendency to concentrate more on leads than rhythm. You'll probably think that playing hot and sexy leads is where it's at as far mandolin playing goes. **Wrong! Rhythm is the most important aspect of good mandolin playing.** (Sorry to shout, but I'm passionate on this point.) Speed and flash mean nothing if your rhythm stinks. If you don't groove, no one who plays with you can groove. It's a delicate thing and it really requires your concentration and dedication.

So, how does one develop good mandolin rhythm? Start by recognizing the importance of good rhythm. Then try to define what that means. Listen to CDs by the masters, Monroe, Flatt & Scruggs, Jimmy Martin, Tony Rice, David Grisman, etc. Learn how those bands work and how they groove. Work your way up to playing along with them. You might make up your own jam CD or cassette of favorite cuts by your favorite bands to play along with. Get started right away by playing along with me on the included CD. As you'll hear, good rhythm is more than keeping metronomic time. Jam with other musicians, especially those slightly better than you, whenever you can. (For more info on jamming, see page 86.) Your rhythmic sense will develop over time if you work on it. And remember, you can't possibly put in too much time on rhythm.

just about anything else for that matter, is to **practice what you don't know, not what you do know.** Work on the things that give you problems, not on the things you already know how to do. Of course your tendency will be to play the things you can play again and again — it's a source of pure joy! But, try to temper that urge with a lust to keep learning and master the things that might be a little weak. Only you can know how much practice a chord, song, or melody needs. I'm not sure that practice makes perfect, but it does make better!

Play through the song and sing along. "Bury Me Beneath the Willow" is a great song and is performed wherever bluegrassers play. As I mentioned before, once you've mastered the chords, try playing the melody, which is shown in both standard notation and tablature. We'll get into playing melodies soon and in a few pages you'll learn about the rules of pick direction, but there's no harm in trying to play a few melodies now.



Photo by Dix Bruce

Gibson "A" model, ca. 1924

Long Journey Home

Key of A $\flat$

A $\flat$

1. Black smoke's a - ris - ing and it sure - ly is a train,
 2. Lost all my mon - ey but a two - dol - lar bill,
 3. Cloud - y in the West and it looks like rain,
 4. Dark and a - rain - ing and I want to go home,
 5. Home - sick and lone - some and I'm feel - ing kind - ly blue.

1 2 4 2 1 4

1 1 3 6 6 6 6 3 3 3 1 6

D $\flat$

A $\flat$

Sure - ly is a train boys, sure - ly is a train,
 Two - dol - lar bill boys, two - dol - lar bill,
 Looks like rain, boys, looks like rain,
 Want to go home, boys, want to go home,
 Feel - ing kind - ly blue, boys, feel - ing kind - ly blue.

1 2 4 2 1

3 3 3 1 6 1 3 3 6 3 1

Black smoke's a - ris - ing and it sure - ly is a
 Lost all my mon - ey but a two - dol - lar
 Cloud - y in the West and it looks like
 Dark and a - rain - ing and I want to go
 Home - sick and lone - some and I'm feel - ing kind - ly

1 1 3 6 6 6 6 3 3 3 1

E $\flat$ 7

A $\flat$

train, I'm on my long jour - ney home.
 bill, I'm on my long jour - ney home.
 rain, I'm on my long jour - ney home.
 home, I'm on my long jour - ney home.
 blue, I'm on my long jour - ney home.

4 2 1 4 1 4

6 6 6 3 1 6 1 6 6

Aura Lee

Key of G

G A7 D7
 As the black - bird in the spring, 'neath the wil - low
 tree, Sat and piped, I heard him sing,
 sing - ing Au - ra Lee, Au - ra Lee,
 Au - ra Lee, maid with gol - den hair,
 Sun - shine came a - long with thee, And swal - lows in the air.

0 5 4 5 0 2 0 5 4 2 4
 5 0 5 4 5 0 2 0 2 2 2
 2 2 2 2 0 0 5 5 4 2 0 5

Ragtime Annie

“Ragtime Annie” also has measure numbers and first and second endings. You’ll notice the first one, “5,” above the treble clef sign in staff two. That tells us that this is the fifth full measure. We don’t count the pickup measure, but start counting with the first full measure.

We also have a new kind of repeat: a *first ending* (found in m8) and a *second ending* (found in m9). This tells us that when we come to the backward-repeat symbol in m8, we go back to the forward-repeat symbol after the pickup measure (as we would with a regular repeat). The difference is that after we play m7 the second time, we skip over m8, and instead play m9. From there, we proceed on to m10 and go from there.

The musical score for "Ragtime Annie" is presented in two systems. The first system begins with a treble clef, a key signature of one sharp (F#), and a common time signature (C). It includes a pickup measure followed by measures 1 through 10. Measure 1 is marked with a dashed line and the label "Measure one". Measure 5 is marked with a dashed line and the label "Measure five". The score includes a "Pickup measure" label, "Pick direction" (down and up arrows), "Finger numbers" (2, 3, 1, 2, 1), and "Repeat symbols" (double bar lines with dots). The second system continues from measure 5, showing measures 5 through 10. It includes a "First ending" (measures 8-9) and a "Second ending" (measure 10). The score includes a "Measure number" (5), "Measure five", "Repeat symbols", and "Finger numbers" (0, 4, 0, 4, 0, 4, 0, 4, 0, 4, 2, 0, 4, 0, 2, 5, 5, 5, 5, 4, 5, 5, 5, 5, 2, 3). The score also includes a "Pickup measure" label, "Pick direction" (down and up arrows), "Finger numbers" (2, 3, 1, 2, 1), and "Repeat symbols" (double bar lines with dots).



Banjo-mandolins

Photo by Dix Bruce

gain strength and stamina. Be sure to start listening to Bill Monroe's Monroe Brothers recordings.

Nine Pound Hammer

solo

Key of G

My Way

1 3 1

2 0 5 2 5 5 5 5

2 2 2 2 2 2 0 0

5 2 2 2 2 2 2 2

2 5 5 5 5 5 5 5

2 0 0 0 0 0 0 0

0 0 0 0 2 0 4 0

5 5 5 5 2 0 4 0

0 5 5 5 5 5 0 5

1 2 3 3 2

2 3 4 5 3

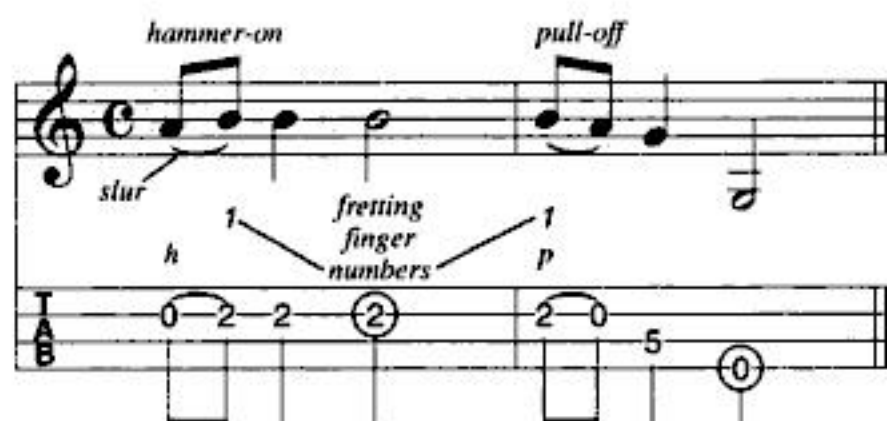
2 0 0 0 0 0 0 0

0 0 0 0 2 0 4 0

5 5 5 5

A *pull* or *pull-off* is the opposite of a hammer. First play a fretted note, and while it's ringing, quickly pull off the fretting finger to sound a lower fretted or open-string note. You can use the finger you are pulling off to pluck the new note. Again, the second note should sound without a second pick stroke.

Both hammers and pulls are shown in the standard notation with slurs. A small “*h*” will signify a hammer; a small “*p*” will signify a pull. Often both the starting and the target notes will be connected with the slur. If not, you’ll usually be starting from or ending on an open string.



Hammers and pulls can affect pick direction, as you can see in the exercise below. For example, in m1 below we have several eighth notes. We play the first with a down pick, the second is played by the hammer with no pick stroke at all. The third eighth note would then be played with a down pick. If you get confused, remember that if the note falls on beat 1, 2, 3, or 4, we play it with a down pick, if the note falls between those beats or on an “and,” play it with an up pick.

The image displays a multi-measure exercise for guitar, consisting of three systems of music. Each system includes a treble clef staff with a key signature of one sharp (F#) and a common time signature (C), and a corresponding guitar fretboard diagram below it. The exercise is divided into measures, with some measures containing multiple eighth notes. Pick direction is indicated by arrows: down arrows for down picks and up arrows for up picks. Hammer-ons (h) and pull-offs (p) are marked with small letters below the notes. Fretting finger numbers (1, 2, 3, 4, 5) are shown below the notes. The fretboard diagram shows the fret numbers for each note, with circles around the 5th fret on the low E string and the 4th fret on the A string. The exercise demonstrates how hammers and pulls affect pick direction, ensuring the correct pick stroke is used for each note.

When the Saints Go Marching In

"When the Saints Go Marching In," a standard in both country and jazz music, recorded by the Monroe Brothers and Flatt & Scruggs among others, combines several slides, hammers and pulls.

When the Saints Go Marching In

solo

Key of G

G

Oh, when the saints, go march-ing in, Oh, when the

1 2 3 s s

5 2 3 5 5 5 5 5 5 5 5 2 3 5 5 5 5 5 5 5 5 5 2 3

D7

saints go march-ing in, Lord I

s h s h p h

5 5 5 5 0 2 2 2 5 5 5 5 0 2 2 2 2 0 0 0 0 0 0 0 0 2 0

G

G7

C

want to be in that num-ber, When the

s h p 2

5 5 5 5 5 5 5 0 2 2 2 5 5 5 5 5 5 3 3 3 3 3 3 3 2 3

G

D7

G

saints go march-ing in,

s h s s

5 5 5 5 0 2 2 2 5 5 5 5 0 0 0 0 5 5 5 5 5 5 5 5 5

More Double Stops: Will the Circle Be Unbroken

Let's try another solo with more slides and lots of double stops. You've already worked with "Will the Circle Be Unbroken" (page 16) so it should be somewhat familiar to you. This solo makes use of the open first and second strings almost as drones to make the most of the double stops. That means you'll only have to fret one of the two notes of the double stop. As usual, the arrows will remind you about pick direction, the numbers tell you which fretting hand fingers to use, the small "s" denotes a slide.

Will the Circle Be Unbroken

solo

Key of A

The musical score is written for a guitar solo in the key of A (two sharps: F# and C#). It consists of four systems of music, each with a treble and bass staff. The time signature is common time (C). The score includes various musical notations such as double stops, slides (marked with 's'), and pick direction arrows. Fingering numbers (1, 2) are provided for the fretting hand. The bass staff often shows open strings (0) and fretted notes (e.g., 2, 4, 7). The first system is labeled 'A' and the second system is labeled 'D'. The third system is labeled 'E' and the fourth system is labeled 'A'.

Banks of the Ohio

solo with tremolo

♩ = tremolo
Key of D

D **A7**

1. I asked my love to take a walk, Just to
say that you'll be mine, In our

2 0 2 4 0 6 2 2 4

D

walk a lit - tle ways, As we
home we'll hap - py be. Down be -

5 0 0 5 4 0 2

G

walked, and as we talked, All
side where the wa - ters flow, On a -

0 4 2 0 5 0 2

D **A7** **D** *fine*

13 bout our wed - ding day, Chorus: On - ly
banks of the O - hi - o.

4 4 5 4 2 0 0 2

A Beautiful Life

backup

Key of G

Wm. Golden, P.D.

melody

1. Each day I'll do, a gol - den deed, By help - ing
2. To be a child of God each day, My light must

back-up

those shine, who are in the need, My life on his earth, praise,
a - long the way, I'll sing his praise,

is but a span, And so I'll do, the best I
while a - ges roll, And try to help, some troub - led

Chords: G, C, G, D, G, C, G, D

Tablature: 5 2 0, 5, 0 5 2, 0, 0 4 5, 3 3 0, 5 2 5, 5 5 2 2 5 5, 3 3 0, 5 2 5, 5 5 2 0 4 0, 0, 3 3 0, 5 2 5, 3 3 0, 5 2 5, 0 5 2, 0, 0 2 5, 2, 5 5 2 2 5 5, 4 1 3 1 3 3, 7 7 3, 5 2 5

Lonesome Valley

basic version in the key of G

Key of G

G

You've got to walk, that lone-some val-ley, You've got to

D **G**

walk, it by your-self, Ain't no-bod-y

C **G**

here, can walk it for you, You've got to

D **G**

walk, it by your-self,

5

Learn the following “Little Maggie” solo in the key of G with the suggested fretting finger numbers. Pay particular attention to the fretting-hand positions the notes form. As you did with “Lonesome Valley,” memorize the solo and the positions. You should be able to play it with your eyes closed.

Little Maggie

solo in the key of G

Key of G

The musical score for "Little Maggie" solo in the key of G is presented in four systems. Each system consists of a treble staff and a bass staff. The treble staff shows the melody with fingerings (1-3, 1-3, 3-2-1, etc.) and the bass staff shows the fretting hand positions with fingerings (1-2, 5-5-5-5-5-5-5-5, etc.). Chord symbols G, D, and F are placed above the treble staff at various points. The score is numbered 1, 5, 9, and 13 at the beginning of each system.

Let's say we need to be able to play this entire solo in the key of A. What we're going to do is move the whole solo, fretting hand fingers and positions, up (toward the bridge) two frets. Before you look at the solo transposed to the key of A below, try it on your own. If you get tangled up, go back to the key of G solo and work from there. Go through the process of teaching your head, eyes, and hands how to move up two frets and maintain the hand positions that you previously learned. This is what you'll have to do in the real world so you might as well practice it now. Once you get it, you'll be able to move the G solo, and ultimately any other melody or solo, up and down the fingerboard to as many as eight or more different positions and keys. Use the solo below to check yourself.

Wayfaring Stranger

basic version in the key of Am

Key of Am

Am Dm

1. I am a poor way-far-ing stran-ger, Travel-ing through this world of
 2. I know dark clouds will ga-ther 'round me, I know my way is rough and

7 Am Dm

woe. And there's no sickness, no toil nor dan-ger, In that bright world,
 steep. But gol-den fields lie just be-fore me, Where souls re-deemed,

14 Am F C

— to which I go. I'm go-ing there to meet my fa-ther, I'm go-ing
 — their vi-gil keep. I'm go-ing there to meet my moth-er, She said she'd

21 F E7 Am

there no more to roam. I am just go-ing o-ver
 meet me when I come. I am just go-ing o-ver

27 Dm E7 Am

Jor-dan, I am just go-ing o-ver home.
 Jor-dan, I am just go-ing o-ver home.

Guitarists often use capos on fiddle tunes to play in keys they like while still providing the fiddler with chords in his or her fiddle key. As a mandolinist, you'll generally play fiddle tunes in the fiddler's key, and nowhere else.

One of the most important things you can do to further your continuing education in bluegrass mandolin is to listen to recordings of the great players and bands on CD. Find players and sounds that really excite you, whether that's Monroe, Flatt & Scruggs (you'll have to make do with CDs), David Grisman, Del McCoury, or Nickel Creek. If you love the music, the song, or solo, you'll listen to it over and over, until you get those sounds into your brain, heart and soul. To really understand bluegrass and be able to play it, you almost need to "memorize" your favorite players and their music. So, crank up the Victrola and also get out and experience music that you love in a live setting.

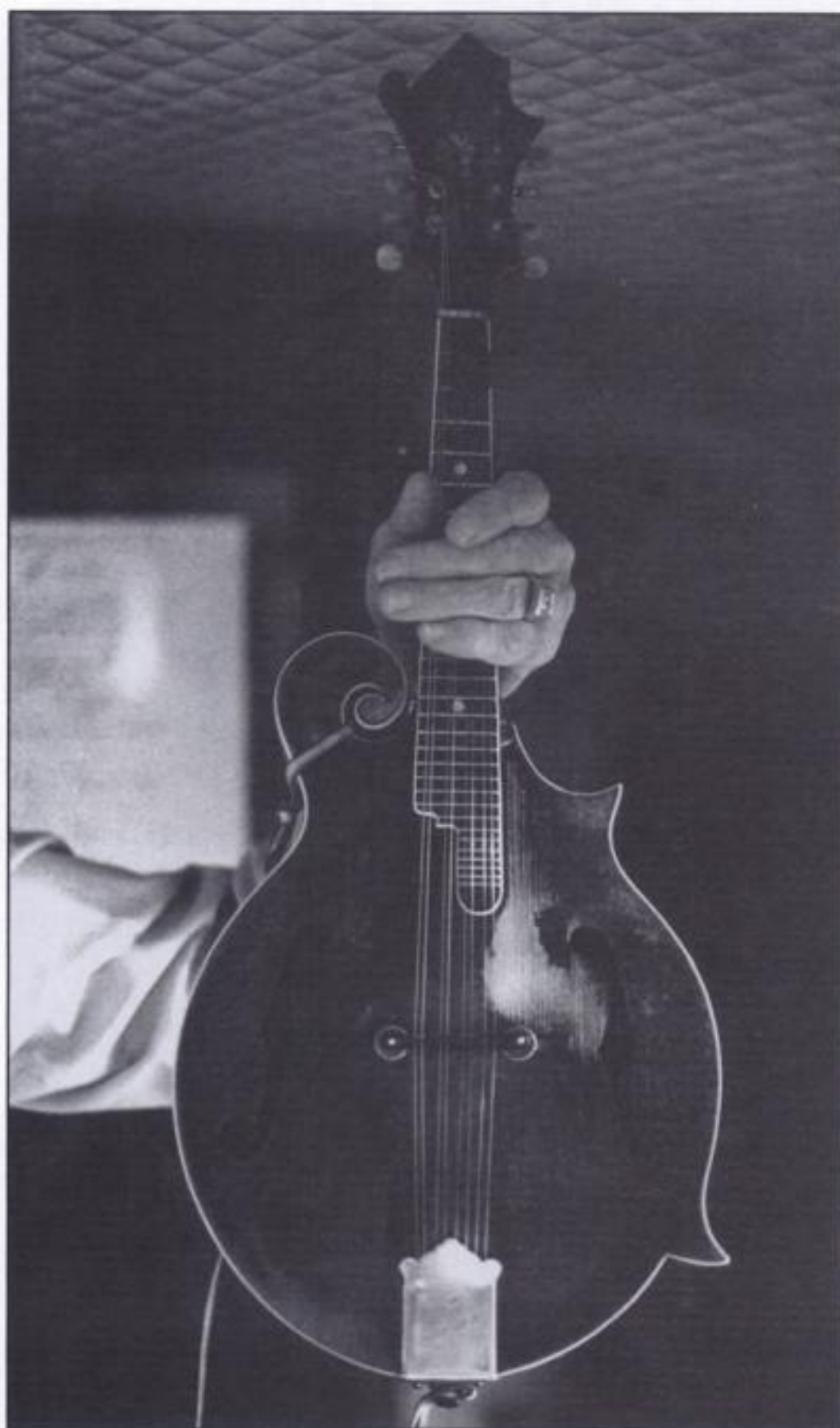


Photo by Dix Bruce

The master's hand with his master model Lloyd Loar F-5

You've previously worked out "Lonesome Valley" in three keys: G, D and C. Here are two kickoffs in C. The first uses some open strings. Can you turn it into a closed position kickoff? Hint: you'll have to change at least one note.

The second kickoff is in closed position and a version of kickoff one played an octave higher with double stops. Move both kickoffs from C to the keys of G and D. Don't forget tremolo on the longer notes.

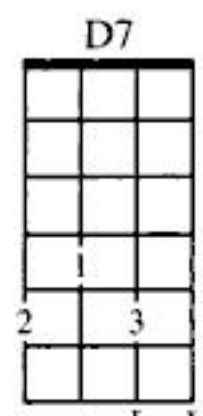
"Lonesome Valley" kickoff 1

"Lonesome Valley" kickoff 2

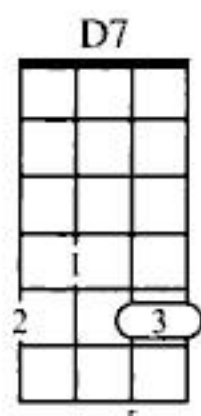
We don't want to forget songs in waltz time or 3/4. Here's a couple of kickoffs for "In the Pines" in G. The first is an *arpeggiated* passage with all chord tones. An *arpeggio* is simply a sequence of chord tones. The second kickoff is in a closed position and uses double stop tremolo.

"In the Pines" kickoff 1

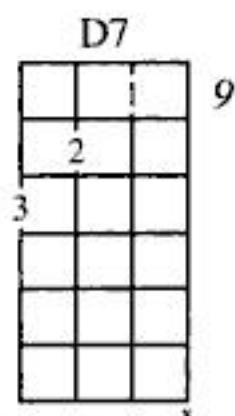
"In the Pines" kickoff 2



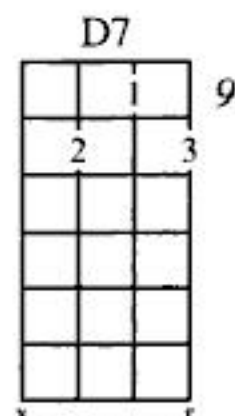
Closed 4th Pos



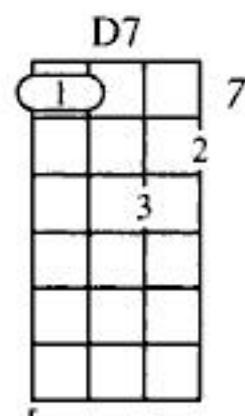
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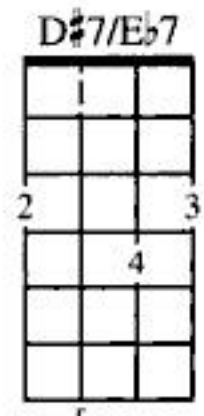
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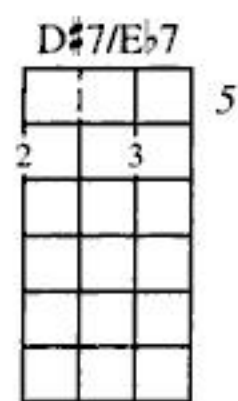
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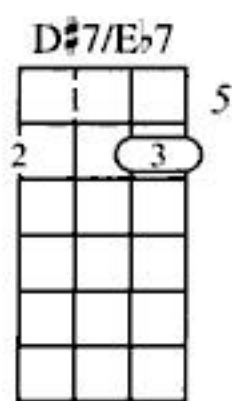
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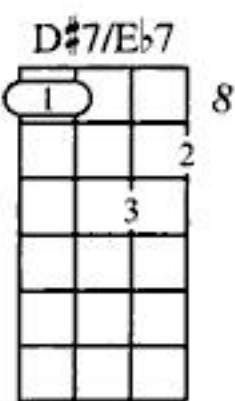
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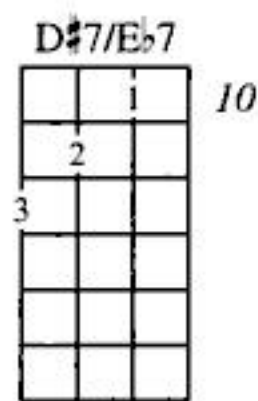
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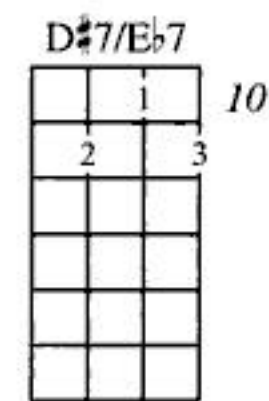
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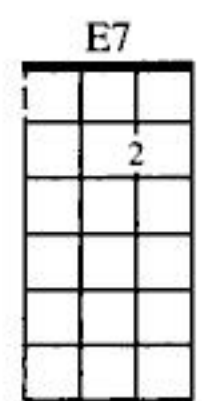
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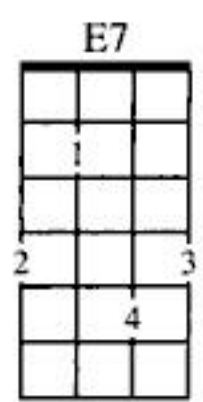
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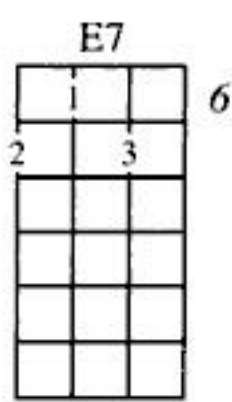
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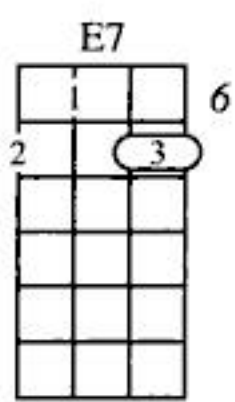
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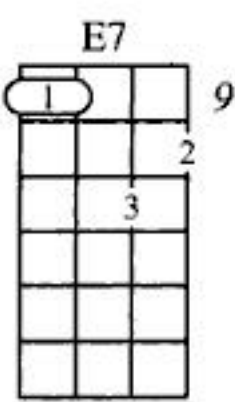
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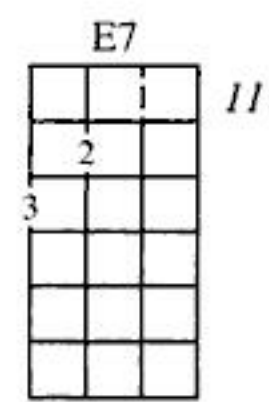
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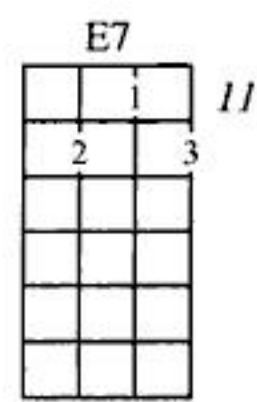
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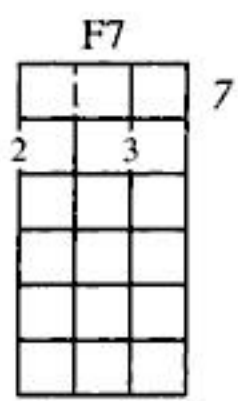
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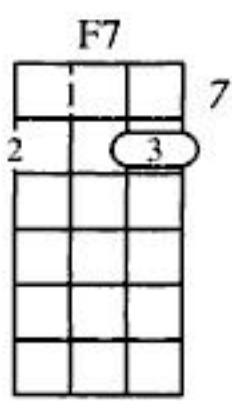
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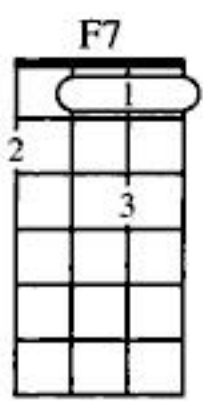
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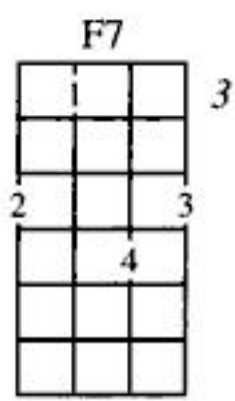
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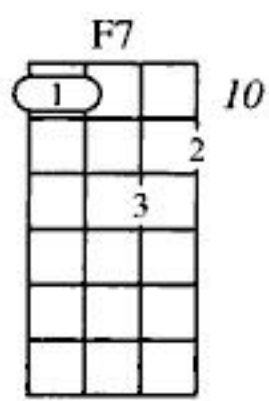
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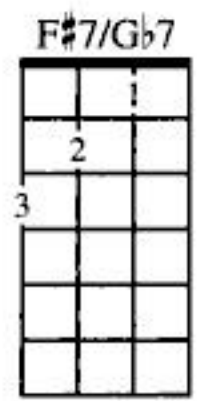
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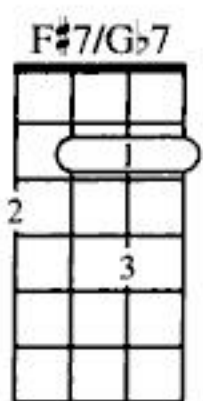
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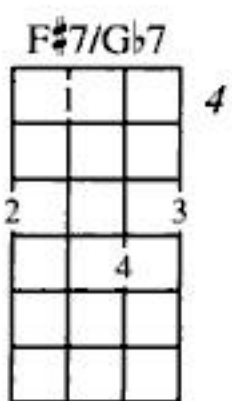
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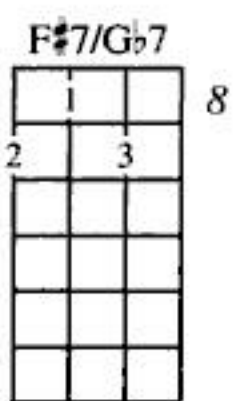
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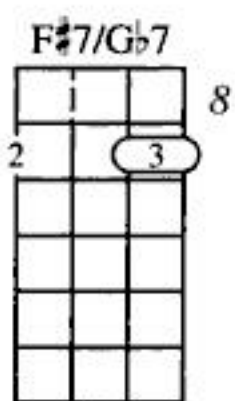
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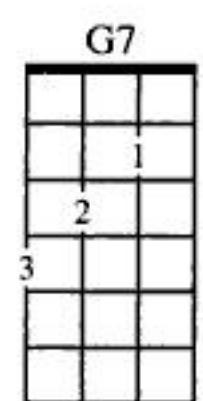
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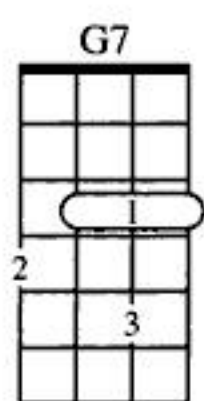
Closed 8th Pos



Closed 8th Pos



Closed 2nd Pos



Closed 3rd Pos

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